Five Bright Planets to Spot in November

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November is a great month for planet watching, in the evening, around midnight, or just before dawn. In the evening, Saturn is the planet of choice, visible well up in the southern sky during mid-to-late evening hours. Through a telescope, the southern side of its famous ring system is currently tilted about 6.5 degrees toward our line of sight.

Around the middle of the night, Mars and Jupiter come into view above the east-northeast **horizon**. Just before dawn, they are high in the southern sky near the Sickle of Leo the Lion. Watch Mars move toward Jupiter early in the month, pass it on November 16, and then sail away to the east for the rest of November.

Venus is the star of the predawn sky. On November 1, it rises 55 minutes before the sun. By November 5, viewers around 40 degrees north **latitude** can see it rise one hour and 25 minutes before the sun and shine 15 degrees above the **horizon** at sunrise. By the end of the month, it rises nearly three and a half hours before the sun. On the next-to-last day, it reaches **magnitude** -4.9, its greatest brightness. Early in the month, a telescope may show it as a hairline **crescent** only a few percent lit.

Mercury joins the morning show from midmonth. It reaches its greatest western **elongation**, 20 degrees from the sun, on November 20. From November 16 to 26, it rises more than 95 minutes before sunrise. A handy measuring tool is your own fist: a clenched fist held at arm's length covers roughly 10 degrees of sky.

Special moments include November 7, when a waning **crescent** moon, Venus, and the blue star Spica bunch together before sunrise, and November 26, when orange-yellow Mars passes the blue-white star Regulus.

Word Treasure

elongation -- How far a planet appears from the sun in the sky, measured in degrees.
magnitude -- A measure of how bright an object in the sky appears.
crescent -- A curved shape showing only a thin lit part of a moon or planet.
horizon -- The line where the Earth and the sky appear to meet.
latitude -- A measure of how far north or south of the equator a place is.

Background you need

The five planets in this guide can be spotted at different times of night during November: some in the evening, some around midnight and some just before dawn.

Where a planet appears depends on the time and on the viewer's position, and a telescope can reveal details such as Saturn's tilted rings or Venus shown as a thin crescent.

Bright stars such as Spica and Regulus act as signposts that help watchers find planets nearby.

Simple measures help too: a clenched fist held at arm's length covers roughly 10 degrees of sky.

Break it down

LEAD: November offers five bright planets to spot in the evening, around midnight or before dawn.

KEY EVENT: Each planet takes its turn, from Saturn in the evening to Venus starring in the predawn sky.

+- EVENING AND MIDNIGHT: Saturn in the south in the evening, then Mars and Jupiter rising in the east-northeast

+- BEFORE DAWN: Venus brightens through the month and Mercury joins the morning show from midmonth

EVIDENCE: Mars passes Jupiter on November 16, and Venus reaches magnitude -4.9, its greatest brightness, on the next-to-last day.

OPEN QUESTION: Special moments to catch include the moon, Venus and Spica bunching together on November 7.

Why it matters

Planet watching needs no special trip, and November gives clear chances to see five different planets. Knowing when and where to look turns an ordinary night sky into a changing show.

Test what you remember

1. Which planet is the planet of choice in the November evening sky?

- (A) Mars
- (B) Venus
- (C) Saturn, visible well up in the southern sky during mid-to-late evening hours
- (D) Mercury

2. On which date does Mars pass Jupiter?

- (A) November 7
- (B) November 16
- (C) November 1
- (D) November 26

3. What magnitude does Venus reach on the next-to-last day of the month, its greatest brightness?

- (A) -4.9
- (B) 6.5 degrees
- (C) 20 degrees
- (D) 15 degrees

4. When does Mercury reach its greatest western elongation of 20 degrees from the sun?

- (A) November 5
- (B) At the end of the month
- (C) November 26
- (D) November 20

5. Roughly how much sky does a clenched fist held at arm's length cover?

- (A) Roughly 10 degrees of sky
- (B) Three and a half hours
- (C) One degree
- (D) About 55 minutes

6. What special sight happens on November 26?

- (A) Orange-yellow Mars passes the blue-white star Regulus
- (B) Saturn's rings tilt toward our line of sight
- (C) A crescent moon bunches with Venus and Spica
- (D) Venus rises before the sun

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):